Levels of Conflict

Notice how far a conflict has gone, then choose a response that fits, from letting the team solve it to stepping in.

Facilitate & Coach · Five Levels of Conflict (Speed B. Leas) · via Lyssa Adkins, Coaching Agile Teams

LEGEND

- Level 1: healthy
- Level 5: get help

1 What Level Are We At?

LISTEN TO THE LANGUAGE

LEVEL	WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT YOU HEAR	SEEN?
1 Problem to Solve	Different views, shared goal. Information is shared openly; people focus on the problem.	*"Let's work out what's going on here."*	☐ Seen
2 Disagreement	Self-protection creeps in. People keep their distance and talk in general terms.	*"I hear you, but..."* *"Some people think..."*	☐ Seen
3 Contest	Winning matters more than solving. Sides form, facts get distorted, it gets personal.	*"You always..."* *"They never..."*	☐ Seen
4 Crusade	Protecting one's own group. Positions harden into principles; the other side is the problem.	*"They're just like that."* *"It's the principle."*	☐ Seen
5 World War	Destroy the other side. Little talk, open hostility; real harm is possible.	*Little is said; people avoid each other.*	☐ Seen

2 The Coach's Move

LEVELS 4-5: GET HELP

WHAT TO DO

1 · Collaborate
Facilitate, then let the team solve it.
Help them reach a decision together.

2 · Support
Coach them to resolve it themselves;
make sure each side is heard.

3 · Facilitate
Get back to facts and interests;
run a structured conversation.

4 · Mediate
Bring in a neutral third party;
talk with each group separately first.

5 · Protect people
Separate the parties and escalate now:
HR or leadership, not the team.

3 What's It About?

FACTS, NOT BLAME

The issue (what happened): _____

_____

Who's involved: _____

Going on since: _____

What each side needs: _____

_____

_____

4 Before You Step In

ASK YOURSELF

- ☐ Is this mine to act on, or the team's to solve?
- ☐ Am I neutral? If not, who is?
- ☐ Have I heard each side on their own?
- ☐ Can the team use its own working agreements?
- ☐ Would naming the level help the team see it?
- ☐ Is anyone at risk of harm?

Harassment, discrimination or safety concerns:
don't mediate. Go to HR or your leadership straight away.

5 Our Next Step

AND WHEN TO CHECK AGAIN

Level now: _____

Move we'll try: _____

_____

With whom: _____

By when: _____

Check again on: _____

Escalate if: _____

"What words are people using, and what level do they point to?"

"Is this conflict about the work, or about each other?"

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